

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN IRAQ

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is honest that Iraq is an oil-dependent, fragile state, that much of its water crisis is driven from beyond its borders, and that there is no landmark community victory to point to — and that protest has been met with deadly force and activists threatened, so the safety of your people comes first. It is built around the levers that do reach here — the marshes' World Heritage status, the oil companies and their commitments, the shared rivers and their norms, and the world's help in restoring these ancient wetlands — and names each in plain words.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Here the loss is ancient and vast: the wetlands that cradled the world's first cities are dying, and with them a culture five thousand years old. Iraq is the ancient land between two great rivers, the Tigris and the Euphrates, whose waters formed the **Mesopotamian Marshes** of the south — the largest wetland ecosystem in the Middle East, a vast floodplain of reeds and open water where the **Marsh Arabs** have fished, herded their water buffalo, harvested the reeds, and built their famed arched reed houses since the time of Sumer. Once drained almost to nothing by Saddam Hussein in a deliberate campaign to punish and displace their people, the marshes partly returned after 2003 and were named a **UNESCO World Heritage Site**. But now they are dying again — starved by the **upstream dams in Turkey and Iran** that hold back the two rivers, parched by years of drought, poisoned by rising salt and pollution, and pressed on their edges by **oil exploration** — while in the oil-soaked south the **gas flares** of the oil fields burn day and night over the towns, fouling the air and the health of whole cities and their children.

A community in Iraq works with real, if indirect, levers — and their distinctive truth is that they reach far beyond a fragile state, through the world that has claimed and helped restore this heritage. The **World Heritage status** of the marshes, and the bodies that guard it (UNESCO), can be invoked against harm. The **international oil companies** that draw the oil operate under **their own commitments and reputations**. The **shared rivers** are governed by the **norms of international waters** and by diplomacy with Turkey and Iran. And the **international attention and funders** behind the marshes' protection can be petitioned and held to their commitments. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. Iraq **lives on oil**, so the state is bound to the industry that flares the gas and presses the marshes. Much of the **water loss comes from beyond its borders** — the dams in Turkey and Iran that Iraq cannot control. And the state is **fragile and at times dangerous**: though it holds elections and has a real civil society, it is corruption-ridden and marked by armed groups, by the deadly repression of protest, and by the threatening of activists — so the safety of your people comes first. So aim for what these levers can deliver, carefully, and with your people's safety first.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

The loss looks beyond reach, but it is a set of pressures the world has a stake in, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. An Iraqi fight turns on the marshes' **World Heritage status**; on the **oil companies' commitments and reputations**; on the **shared-river diplomacy** and the norms of international waters; and on the **international restoration effort**. Every one of those reaches beyond a fragile state, into the world

that has claimed and helped restore this heritage. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull — safely.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you begin — and mind your safety in a dangerous space — work out your real situation:

- **If it threatens the marshes, their World Heritage status is your sharpest lever** — a heritage the world has claimed can be defended through UNESCO and the world's attention.
- **If it's the oil, the international companies' commitments and reputations are a real route** — they guard their names, and the gas flares and pollution breach their standards.
- **If it's the water, the shared-river norms and diplomacy are the arena** — the harm is largely from upstream dams Iraq cannot control, so the fight is diplomatic and international.
- **If the state is fragile and dangerous, don't rely on confrontation** — protest has been met with deadly force, so reach the world's levers and put safety first.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **defend the marshes through the world that claimed and restored them** — the heritage status, the restoration effort — and **hold the oil companies to their commitments and press the shared-river diplomacy** — and do it all carefully, with your people's safety first.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a harm is addressed, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The state, dependent on oil for almost all its revenue, is bound to the industry — but the marshes carry **World Heritage status** guarded by **UNESCO**; the **international oil companies** operate under their own commitments and reputations; the **rivers** are governed by shared-river norms and diplomacy with Turkey and Iran; and the **international restoration effort** has a stake and a purpose. Iraq's own **civil society, courts, and elections** are real but fragile. Know which of these you can reach — the world's levers reach furthest, the state the least.

How a Harm Moves — and Where You Jump In

The marshes and the heritage. *Your opening:* invoke the **World Heritage status** and UNESCO against harm to the marshes.

The oil and the companies. *Your opening:* hold the **international oil companies** to their commitments and reputations over the gas flares, the pollution, and the pressure on the marshes.

The shared rivers. *Your opening:* press the **shared-river diplomacy** and the norms of international waters against the upstream dams' harm.

The restoration effort. *Your opening:* enlist the **international restoration effort** and hold it to its purpose — protecting the marshes and their people.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who does the harm and who's behind them** — the international oil companies (reachable through commitments and reputation) and the upstream dams (reachable through diplomacy).

What global stake it touches — the World Heritage status, the restoration money — because the world's

stake is your lever. **What commitments it breaches** — the companies' standards, the shared-river norms, the heritage obligations.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. **UNESCO** and the **World Heritage bodies** guard the marshes. The **international oil companies** hold commitments and reputations. **Shared-river diplomacy** and international-water norms govern the rivers. The **international restoration effort** funds and guides the marshes' recovery. And Iraq's — and the world's — **environmental and Marsh Arab organisations, scientists, and international networks** are the forces that reach furthest, carrying a local harm to the world that claimed the heritage.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises, and there is no landmark win here. What most moves them: whether the world's stake can be engaged, whether the oil companies can be reached, and how dangerous and constrained the space is.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost/Risk	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Invoke World Heritage status (UNESCO)	25–50%	months–yr	low	Harm to the marshes challenged
Hold oil companies to commitments	25–50%	months–yr	low	Flaring/pollution curbed; standards pressed
Shared-river diplomacy / water norms	15–40%	years	low	Upstream harm raised; pressure applied
Enlist the international restoration effort	30–55%	months–yr	low	Money and expertise held to purpose
Document harm (marshes / air / health)	25–50%	weeks–months	low–risk	Undeniable evidence for the world
International attention + networks	30–55%	months–yr	low	A global heritage's loss exposed
Everything together (heritage, oil, water, restoration)	30–55%	months–years	mod	Heritage defended; harm curbed; restoration secured
Direct confrontation with the state	5–20%	—	high risk	Often ineffective and dangerous

The levers that move the needle most are the **World Heritage status** and the **international restoration effort**, and **holding the oil companies to their commitments**, backed by **shared-river diplomacy** and international attention. There's no landmark ceiling to cite — the honest floor is an oil-bound state, water loss from beyond the borders, and a dangerous, fragile space. So aim for the heritage defended and its status pressed, oil harm curbed, water diplomacy advanced, and restoration secured.

On cost and risk: invoking the heritage, reaching the oil companies, and enlisting the restoration effort are low-cost; but documenting harm and any protest in a dangerous space carry real risk — protest has been met with deadly force and activists threatened. The great strength is that the world has claimed and helped restore this heritage; the great

requirement is to reach the world's levers rather than confront a dangerous state, and to keep your people safe.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the harm" is weak. Being specific — this heritage breach, this oil company's flaring, this upstream dam — is strong. Answer five questions in writing, carefully.

1. What is the harm, and who's responsible? The threat to the marshes (oil, salt, drought), the gas flares and pollution (the oil companies), or the water loss (the upstream dams).

2. What global stake does it touch? The marshes' **World Heritage status**, the **international restoration effort**, an international **oil company's** commitments — **the world's stake is your sharpest lever**.

3. What commitments or norms does it breach? The heritage obligations, the oil companies' standards, the shared-river norms — the gap you can press.

4. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline? Is a heritage review, an oil operation, a water negotiation, or a restoration decision in play? These openings matter.

5. Who stands with you, and who's at risk? Marsh Arab and environmental organisations, scientists, international networks — and, carefully, in a dangerous space, a clear plan for the safety of those who document or speak.

What this looks like in real life. Oil exploration and gas flaring press the dying marshes, as upstream dams starve them of water. The five questions yield: the oil companies and the upstream dams; the World Heritage status and the restoration effort (the world's stake); the commitments and norms breached; a heritage or oil or water decision in play; and organisations and networks, with a safety plan. That's the Iraqi pattern — defend the heritage, hold the oil companies to their commitments, press the water diplomacy, and enlist the restoration effort, safely.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can reach the world and one that can't is documented harm and breach. Build it in three layers, carefully.

Layer one: the harm to the marshes, air, and health. Document the **dying marshes** (the drying, the salt, the oil pressure), the **gas flares** and the pollution over the towns, and the harm to the Marsh Arabs' livelihood and to health — with dated evidence, testimony, and, where safe, imagery and data.

Layer two: the global stake and the breach. Get the marshes' **World Heritage designation** and its obligations, the oil companies' **commitments and standards**, and the **shared-river norms**, and identify the **breach** — the gap between the world's stake and the harm.

Layer three: the map of harm and stake. Lay the harm over the World Heritage marshes, the oil operations, and the restoration effort, so the world's stake in the loss is undeniable. Walking into UNESCO, the oil companies, the shared-river diplomacy, the restoration bodies, or international networks with documented harm and a documented breach is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The harm** — the dying marshes, the gas flares, the pollution, the health toll — with dated evidence and testimony, gathered safely.
- **The World Heritage designation and its obligations** — from UNESCO and the heritage record.
- **The oil companies' commitments and standards** — from their own materials.
- **The shared-river norms** — the international-water framework governing the Tigris and Euphrates.
- **The map of harm and global stake** — the marshes, the oil, the restoration effort, laid together.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a coalition that reaches the world — carefully — gives you leverage a fragile state cannot block. Build in four moves, safely.

Root it in the Marsh Arabs and the affected communities. The marshes are the Marsh Arabs' ancient home and living, and the flares foul whole cities. Root the fight there, honouring a five-thousand-year culture.

Bring in organisations, scientists, and networks — carefully. Enlist Marsh Arab and environmental organisations, scientists, and international networks who can document the harm and reach UNESCO, the oil companies, and the restoration effort — mindful of the danger and everyone's safety.

Reach the world that claimed the heritage. The distinctive Iraqi lever: take the harm to **UNESCO and the World Heritage bodies**, the **oil companies' commitments**, the **shared-river diplomacy**, and the **international restoration effort** — the world that has claimed and helped restore this heritage, and can be asked to defend it.

Build to last, and put safety first. In a fragile, dangerous space, build careful roles, a secure archive, and — above all — a **safety plan** for those who document or speak, because protest has been met with deadly force. Avoid needless confrontation; the world's levers are both safer and often more effective.

STEP 4: THE HERITAGE, THE OIL COMPANIES & THE SHARED RIVERS

Iraq's sharpest levers reach beyond the fragile state, into the world that has claimed and helped restore the marshes.

The World Heritage Status

The distinctive lever: the marshes are a **UNESCO World Heritage Site** of global value. Invoke that status and the bodies that guard it against harm — oil pressure, water loss, degradation — because a heritage the world has claimed can be defended through the world's attention and UNESCO's mechanisms.

The Oil Companies and Their Commitments

The oil that fouls the south is drawn by **international companies who guard their names** and operate under **their own commitments and standards**. The gas flares, the pollution, and the pressure on the marshes breach those commitments — hold the companies to them, and to their reputations, which reach beyond the state.

The Shared Rivers and the Restoration Effort

The rivers are shared with Turkey and Iran and governed by the **norms of international waters** — press the **shared-river diplomacy**, with international support, against the upstream dams' harm, understanding the leverage is diplomatic, not direct. And enlist the **international restoration effort** — the money and expertise the world has poured into the marshes — holding it to its purpose of protecting the marshes and their people.

The Honest Limits — and Safety

Straight talk: these levers are real but indirect, the state is oil-bound and dangerous, the water loss is largely from beyond the borders, and there's no landmark win. Direct confrontation carries deadly risk. So use the world's levers — the heritage, the oil companies, the shared rivers, the restoration effort — carefully, safely, and count the heritage defended, oil harm curbed, water diplomacy advanced, and restoration secured as real wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Harm becomes a threat to a world heritage. Not "the marshes are dying" but *"a UNESCO World Heritage Site of global value, cradle of the world's first cities, is being killed by oil, salt, and starved water — and the world has a duty to it."*

Flaring becomes a breach of commitment. *"The gas flares over our towns breach the oil companies' own standards and foul our children's air."*

Water loss becomes a diplomatic case. *"The rivers are shared, and the upstream dams' harm is a matter for international-water norms and diplomacy."*

Restoration becomes a demand. *"The world poured money and expertise into these marshes — that effort must protect them and their people, not be squandered."*

Match it to the venue: the heritage harm to UNESCO and the world; the flaring to the oil companies and their reputations; the water loss to the shared-river diplomacy; the restoration to the international effort. Keep it careful and safe.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Iraq, international attention is the distinctive lever, because the marshes are a world heritage and the oil is drawn by reputation-conscious global companies — a heritage the world has claimed and helped restore carries far. International networks make the media front reach far. But in a dangerous space, care and safety come first.

Lead with the ancient heritage and the harm, not procedure. Not "the assessment was deficient" but "the wetlands that cradled the world's first cities, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, are being killed by oil and starved water, and their five-thousand-year culture with them." Use your strongest material: the dying marshes, the gas flares, the health toll, and the Marsh Arabs' voices.

Work several audiences at once — reach the world. Careful domestic attention where safe; and above all UNESCO, the oil companies, the restoration bodies, and the global press, where a world heritage's loss is most exposed. Make it easy: clear summaries, imagery where safe, careful testimony.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit hard-won proof. And protect people — in a dangerous space where protest has met deadly force, carry the fight carefully, prioritise the international route, and safeguard those exposed.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything; and mind your safety.

8A — Invoking World Heritage status (to UNESCO / heritage bodies).

Subject: Threat to the Mesopotamian Marshes World Heritage Site.

"We report that the Mesopotamian Marshes, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, are threatened by [oil pressure / water loss / degradation]: [specifics]. We ask the World Heritage bodies to act. [Attach evidence.]"

8B — To an international oil company (its commitments).

Subject: Gas flaring and marsh harm — breach of your standards.

"We, the community of [place], document that your [flaring / pollution / operations] foul our air and press the World Heritage marshes, in breach of your own commitments: [specifics]. We ask you to remedy it. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — On the shared rivers (to authorities / international bodies).

Subject: The shared rivers and the dying marshes.

"We ask that the harm to the Tigris and Euphrates and the marshes from the upstream dams be raised in the shared-river diplomacy and under international-water norms, with international support. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — To the international restoration effort.

Subject: Holding the marsh restoration to its purpose.

"We, the community of [place], ask that the international restoration effort for the marshes be held to its purpose — protecting the wetlands and their people against [the current harm]. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — To an environmental / Marsh Arab organisation.

Subject: The marshes and our community harmed — Iraq.

"Our marshes and air are being harmed by [oil / water loss / flaring]. We've documented it. We ask for your help to reach UNESCO, the oil companies, and the restoration effort. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — Documenting the health / air harm (to authorities).

Subject: Gas flaring and our health — [town].

"We, residents of [town], document that the gas flares foul our air and harm our health: [specifics]. We demand they be curbed. [Attach evidence.]"

8G — Letter to the (international) press.

Subject: The cradle of civilisation is dying — the Mesopotamian Marshes.

"The World Heritage marshes, home to the Marsh Arabs since Sumer, are being killed by oil, salt, and starved water. We can provide documented harm, imagery, and testimony. [Contact.]"

8H — Uniting the community (carefully).

Subject: Our marshes, our air — let's reach the world that claimed them.

"The marshes are dying and the flares foul our air. The world named our marshes a heritage and helped restore them — let's ask it to defend them, and hold the oil companies to their word. Let's do it safely, together. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean — and safely — do these six things, in order:

1. **Document the harm — the dying marshes, the flares, the health toll — carefully.**
2. **Invoke the World Heritage status with UNESCO (8A) — your sharpest lever.**
3. **Hold the oil companies to their commitments (8B).**
4. **Press the shared-river diplomacy on the water loss (8C).**
5. **Enlist the international restoration effort (8D), and reach an organisation (8E).**
6. **Reach the international press — a dying world heritage (8G) — and mind your safety.**

Even lean, those six reach the world that claimed the heritage — the Iraqi template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Iraq's field is tilted by oil dependence, external water control, and danger, so plan for it — and for safety.

When the state is bound to oil. Expect it — oil is the revenue. Reach the international oil companies through their commitments and reputations, and the world through the heritage, which sit beyond the state's protection.

When the water loss is from beyond the borders. The dams in Turkey and Iran are beyond Iraq's control. Work the shared-river diplomacy and international-water norms, with international support — the leverage is diplomatic, not direct.

When the space is dangerous. Protest has met deadly force and activists have been threatened. Prioritise the international, heritage, and restoration routes, which are both safer and often more effective, and protect those exposed.

When there's no precedent. This is a hard, dangerous field. Build the case on the world's stake — the heritage, the oil companies, the restoration — and lay down the accountability that can grow.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Iraq has serious, documented problems with corruption in the oil sector and the handling of restoration and water funds, so this matters — but tread carefully in a dangerous space.

How to spot it. Restoration and water money diverted; oil deals against the communities' interest; flaring and pollution tolerated for the connected; benefits to officials while the marshes die and the towns choke.

Who's supposed to guard against it. **UNESCO** and the international heritage bodies guard the marshes' status. The **international oil companies** and their financiers can be held to standards. The **international restoration effort** can audit its money. And Iraq's — and the world's — **environmental and Marsh Arab organisations and press** can expose a betrayal.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how money was diverted, how a commitment was broken, who benefits — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. In a dangerous space, route serious evidence to UNESCO, the international bodies, the restoration effort, and trusted journalists rather than making risky public accusations, and protect those exposed. Pair the exposure with the heritage and oil-commitment case.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, and safely. The documented harm and breach build your case; the World Heritage status and the world's stake aim it; the Marsh Arab and affected communities are the muscle; UNESCO, the oil companies, the shared-river diplomacy, and the restoration effort press it; international attention exposes it. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and safety comes first throughout.

Early on (weeks 1–8): document the harm to the marshes, air, and health; invoke the World Heritage status; identify the oil companies' and shared-river commitments; root the fight in the communities; build careful support and a safety plan.

In the thick of it (months–year+): hold the oil companies to their commitments; press the shared-river diplomacy; enlist the restoration effort; reach the international press.

The long haul (year+ / years): carry the heritage, oil, water, and restoration pressure; keep the coalition ready; hold the line for the heritage defended, oil harm curbed, water diplomacy advanced, and restoration secured — keeping your people safe.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Defending the marshes, rivers, and air of Iraq is a fight without a landmark victory to point to — but not without levers, because the world has claimed these ancient wetlands as its heritage and poured money into restoring them, and can be asked to defend them. Hold both truths. The distinctive power here is real: the marshes' World Heritage status and the bodies that guard it, the international oil companies and their commitments and reputations, the shared rivers governed by the norms of international waters, and the international restoration effort — levers that reach far beyond a fragile state, into the world that claimed the heritage. And the constraints are real and grave: an oil-bound state, a water loss driven from beyond the borders by dams Iraq cannot control, and a fragile, dangerous space where protest has met deadly force and activists have been threatened.

Here's the discipline that wins what can be won — safely. Document the harm — the dying marshes, the gas flares, the poisoned air and health — carefully. Then reach the world that claimed the heritage: invoke the World Heritage status with UNESCO, hold the international oil companies to their own commitments and reputations over the flaring and the pressure on the marshes, press the shared-river diplomacy and the norms of international waters against the upstream dams, and enlist the international restoration effort, holding it to its purpose of protecting the marshes and their people. Root the fight in the Marsh Arabs and the affected communities, and carry it to the international press, where a dying world heritage carries far. And above all, in a dangerous space, prioritise the world's levers over risky confrontation, and keep your people safe. Count the heritage defended, oil harm curbed, water diplomacy advanced, and restoration secured as real wins — a heritage the world has claimed and helped restore, defended through the world that claimed it. So can you.